



MARCH 19th 2026
CHARTER REVISION
COMMISSION AGENDA
AMENDED

Date: Thursday March 19, 2026

Time: 6:00 PM

Location: 108 E Green Street

Watch Online: <https://www.youtube.com/@CityofIthacaPublicMeetings>

1. Call to Order

1.1 Emergency Evacuation Notice

2. Agenda Review

3. Chair's Remarks

3.1 Charter Revisions, History & Balance of Powers

3.2 Description of Charter Revision Commission's Process (for Public, with Vice Chair)

4. Mayor's Q&A

5.1 Remarks (5 mins)

5.2 Q&A with Commissioners (5 mins)

5. Public Comment Segment (20 mins limit)

6. Resolution No. 3, Amendments Proposed

5.1 To Modernize, Simplify, and Maximize Council Powers under State Law (Legislative)

5.2 To Enforce Council Attendance (Legislative)

5.3 To Authorize Council to Prohibit Abstentions (Legislative)

5.4 To Simplify City Boundaries (Elections)

5.5 To Simplify Ward & Electoral District Boundaries (Elections)

5.6 To Incorporate GIAC & IYB as Distinct Entities in the Charter (General)

5.7 To Simplify Search Process of Department Heads under City Manager (Steering)

5.8 To Merge sections concerning City Prosecutor with City Attorney (Steering)

5.9 To Indicate Allocation of Spending Reflecting Current Budgetary Practices (Steering)

5.10 To Align borrowing in anticipation of tax revenue with NYS Law (Steering)

5.11 To Provide any qualified voter may vote in special elections to raise revenue (Steering)

5.12 To Move provisions on Sick Leave to the City Code (Steering)

5.13 To Establish the Charter's Supremacy (Steering)

5.14 To Clarify City intends to exercise power under State Law (Steering)

7. Reports from Working Groups (Time Permitting)

6.1 Legislative Powers

6.2 Elections

6.3 General

8. Updated Working Group Assignments

7.1 Reminder of Working Group Procedure

7.2 Announcement of Working Group Assignments

9. Next Steps & Adjournment

7.1 Immediate Actions

7.2 Next Meeting Date

Submission of Written Comments.

Not every citizen may find themselves able to attend the Public Comment section of the meeting. To Submit written comments via the commission form please use this [link](#).

Written comments submitted will be compiled and entered into the record.



The City of Ithaca, New York
Charter Revision Commission
Ithaca City Hall, 108 E. Green St.
Ithaca, NY 14850

Charter Revision Commission Resolution No. 3

A Resolution to Adopt the First Series of Recommendations of the Legislative Working Group

For Consideration at the March 19, 2026
Meeting of the Charter Revision Commission

WHEREAS, Robert G. Cantelmo, mayor of the City of Ithaca, pursuant to Section 36 of the Municipal Home Rule Law, established a charter revision commission on January 23, 2026;

WHEREAS, the Charter Revision Commission (hereafter “the Commission”) in Resolution No. 1 adopted on February 19, 2026, appointed of Office of the City Attorney as counsel to the Commission;

WHEREAS, the Commission desires the preparation of draft language to amend the City of Ithaca Charter;

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED, the Commission requests the Office of the City Attorney either draft language for or provide a written explanation as to the technical or legal reasons hindering the adoption of the enumerated proposed charter amendments below.

Legislative Working Group (Kristina Thelen, Chair)

1. An amendment to modernize and simplify §C-36 to grant the Common Council the maximum powers it is permitted to hold under the New York Constitution and state law.
2. An amendment to §C-32 to authorize the Common Council to promulgate rules providing for the removal of a member of the Common Council upon such a member accruing more than three (3) consecutive unexcused absences from regular voting meetings.
3. An amendment to authorize the Common Council to promulgate rules providing for the prohibition of abstentions.



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Elections Working Group (Donna Fleming, Chair)

4. An amendment to fully strike Article I §C-2 “Boundaries of the City,” and replace it with language indicating that the boundaries of the City of Ithaca will be shown on the official city boundary map that will be filed in the office of the City Clerk. Furthermore, this new wording should note that modifications to the boundaries of the city will be shown on an updated official city boundary map, to be filed in the office of the City Clerk.

5. An amendment to fully strike Article I §C-3 and strike Article II §C-8B 1-19, while replacing them with language indicating that official maps of ward and election district boundaries, with appropriate keys, will be filed in the office of the City Clerk and the Tompkins County Board of Elections and will be available for public inspection.

General Working Group (Aryeal Jackson, Chair)

6. An amendment to incorporate the Greater Ithaca Activities Center (GIAC) and Ithaca Youth Bureau in the Charter (i.e.: creation of section § C-X in Article II).

Steering Committee (Billy Noseworthy, Chair)

7. An amendment to the procedure for department head searches that simplifies the search and appointment process to align with best practices and provides for the final approval of the Common Council for each appointment (refer to § C-22, § C-5).

8. An amendment to merge the section concerning the City Prosecutor (§ C-27) with the section concerning the City Attorney (§ C-24).

9. An amendment to revise Article IV §C-39A such that the language around subsections 1-3 is streamlined and appropriately revised to indicate the allocation of spending across all departments, agencies, funds, and Council expenditures reflecting current budgetary practices under the current form of government.

10. An amendment to revise Article IV §C-48 such that the longer “borrowing in anticipation of tax revenue” clause is replaced by a modernized, shorter clause indicating the City may borrow funds in anticipation of tax revenues as permitted by New York Local Finance Law, Chapter 33-A.

11. An amendment to correct Article IV §C-52B to provide that any registered voter qualified to vote in an election in the city may vote in special elections described in this provision.



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12. An amendment to move §C-109, which concerns sick leave of City employees, to the relevant portion of the City Code. (This amendment should include relevant transitional language.)
13. An amendment to establish the Charter's supremacy over all inconsistent local laws, ordinance, and resolutions at its outset (i.e.: creation of section § C-X in Article I).
14. An amendment to indicate the City intends to exercise power permitted under state law (i.e.: creation of section § C-X in Article I).



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Announcement of Steering Committee & Working Group Appointments, No. 2

Pursuant to the authority of the Chair, I am announcing the revised appointments to our standing steering committee, and working groups of the City of Ithaca Charter Revision Commission.

These appointments were informed by members' stated bandwidth and accessibility considerations, along with the goal of balancing expertise, continuity, and representation across committees and working groups. All working groups are advisory to the full Commission, while the Steering Committee guides the process.

The committee appointments are as follows:

Steering Committee

- Billy Noseworthy, Chair
- Victor Kessler, Vice Chair
- Clyde Lederman, Secretary
- Miranda Pagan, Member
- Donna Fleming, Member

Legislative Powers Working Group

- Kristina Thelen, Working Group Chair
- George McGonigal, Member
- Travis Brooks, Member
- Nels Bohn, Member
- Nathan Sitaraman, Member
- Clyde Lederman, Liason

Elections Working Group

- Donna Fleming, Working Group Chair
- Tiffany Kumar, Member
- Deborah Fisher, Member
- Miranda Pagan, Member
- Clyde Lederman, Liason

Boards, Commissions & Departments Working Group

- Aryeal Jackson, Working Group Chair
- Cynthia Brock, Member
- Kristina Thelen, Member
- Nathan Sitaraman, Member
- Travis Brooks, Member
- Clyde Lederman, Liason

Each working group shall have one additional member, appointed by the Office of the City Attorney.

These appointments take effect immediately. Working groups are encouraged to organize their initial meetings, coordinate schedules mindful of accessibility needs, and report regularly to the full Commission.

To support transparency and shared understanding, working groups are requested to circulate notes to the full Commission within one week of meeting.

I want to thank all commissioners for their flexibility and willingness to serve. If any member has a concern regarding their assignment, I ask that they contact me directly so we can address it promptly.

This announcement will be entered into the record.